

# Whistleblower and Ethics Reporting Policy

## Purpose

This policy gives every Contoso Corp employee a clear, safe way to report suspected illegal activity, fraud, or serious ethical violations, and confirms that Contoso Corp will not tolerate retaliation against anyone who reports in good faith. A report does not need to turn out to be correct to be made in good faith — good faith means the employee honestly believed the concern was legitimate at the time they raised it, not that the concern is later proven true.

## What to Report

Report concerns involving financial fraud or accounting irregularities, bribery or corruption, safety violations, discrimination or harassment not already resolved through normal HR channels, misuse of company funds or assets, or any activity the employee believes violates the law or Contoso Corp's Code of Conduct. Ordinary workplace disagreements or dissatisfaction with a business decision are not whistleblower matters and should go through a manager or HR business partner instead.

## How to Report

Reports can be made to a manager, HR, Legal, or directly through the Contoso Ethics Hotline at 1-800-555-0142, available 24/7 and operated by an independent third party, not by Contoso Corp staff. Employees may also submit a report through the Ethics Hotline's web portal, which supports secure two-way follow-up messaging with the investigator without revealing the reporter's identity.

## Anonymous Reporting Option

Reports may be submitted anonymously through the Ethics Hotline; the independent third-party operator does not collect or pass along identifying information unless the reporter chooses to provide it. Anonymous reports are investigated with the same seriousness as identified reports, though an anonymous reporter cannot always be contacted for follow-up clarifying questions, which can occasionally limit how thoroughly a vague anonymous report can be investigated.

## Non-Retaliation Protection

Contoso Corp strictly prohibits retaliation against anyone who reports a concern in good faith or participates in an investigation, including firing, demotion, pay reduction, negative performance reviews issued because of the report, or exclusion from meetings and opportunities. An employee who believes they have experienced retaliation should report it immediately through the same Ethics Hotline channels; retaliation complaints are investigated independently of, and with the same urgency as, the

original underlying report.

## **Investigation Process**

Legal or an independent investigator (for reports involving senior leadership) reviews each report, determines its scope, and completes most investigations within 45 business days, though complex financial or legal matters may take longer. The reporter, if identified, receives a general update on whether the investigation is complete, but detailed findings are shared only on a need-to-know basis to protect the privacy of everyone involved, including any employee who was the subject of the report.

## **Frequently Asked Questions**

Will I get in trouble if my report turns out to be unfounded? No, as long as the report was made in good faith. Only reports made maliciously, or with knowledge that the claim was false, can result in consequences for the reporter.

Can I report a concern about my own manager? Yes — reports about a direct manager go through the same Ethics Hotline and are handled by Legal or HR, never by the manager being reported on, and never routed back through that manager for awareness before the investigation begins.

## **Roles and Responsibilities**

Employees are responsible for reporting suspected violations in good faith through any of the channels described above. Legal owns the investigation process for reports involving fraud, legal violations, or senior leadership. HR investigates reports primarily involving workplace conduct. The independent Ethics Hotline operator maintains reporter confidentiality and anonymity where requested.